

How we Test



It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.

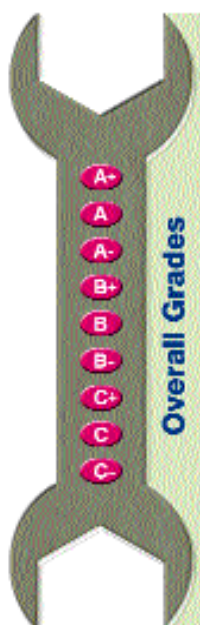
Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived



taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.

In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality/features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (▶).

The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar

▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application

In Test this Month

The comparison test this month aims to present you with the right acoustic offering for your PC. We first evaluated 29 speakers that delivered everything from a 2.1-channel sound for general home use, to a complete 5.1 surround setup for a Dolby Digital experience. Find out which speaker sets emerged unscathed from our gruelling sound quality and performance tests to offer you the best audio solution for your needs.

Soundcards provide the easel on which the speakers paint their magic. We thus checked out six soundcards that will convert your dull computer into an aural beast fit to stalk even the best Hi-fi systems. Our bag of tricks included performance tests to test the mettle of every soundcard, even as we grilled each card on the features that it offered. The cards we tested are sure to please your ears, whether you are on a budget, or are looking for the most professional solution.

Finally, to complete the picture, we brought in the MP3 players. With MP3 music blaring out of every computer in the world, we thought it time you carried the music along. We thus tested six portable MP3 players; within the array you will find both solid state devices and CD-based solutions.

In our Bazaar section we bring you the first-ever test of some of the hottest products and technologies in the country. This month we put the fastest CD-Writer to the test—the LITEON 48x. We also evaluate the Intel Celeron 1.7 GHz processor.